

LENS LEGACY
'Ellora Eyes' (teak panel, 12 archival pigment prints), 2024, by Dayanita Singh

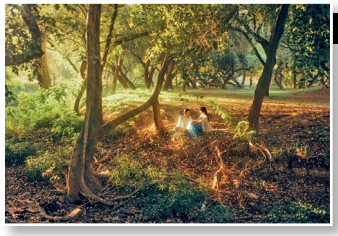
tween the artists. "The tanpura is never centre stage, because it's an accompaniment instrument and yet without it, you can't have any music," she says. Following from the JNAF exhibition, Singh's retrospective will split into two in March-April 2025—*Mona and Myself* at Gallery White, Vadodara, and *Photo Architecture* at Ahmedabad's Kanoria Centre for Arts. These shows will include additional images and other material, for example, a video of the late architect B.V. Doshi talking about the photographs that Singh made in his Ahmedabad home.

Singh also plans to take the touring exhibition to more venues next year. "I'm hoping that I can take what I showed in Kolkata to Varanasi, but to five venues instead of one," she says. Similarly, she wants to take *Photo Lies* to all cities with eminent architecture schools. "There are many questions in this show for architects. What is it that connects Padmanabhapuram Palace to Geoffrey Bawa? What connects Martand Khosla to Carlo Scarpa? They don't know each other, they come from very different times and geographies and yet in my work, they blend seamlessly—pun intended, since they blend because of the seam," she adds. ■

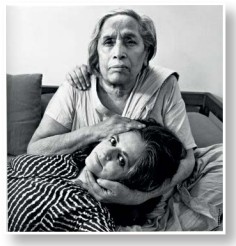
–Prachi Joshi

***Photo Lies* will continue at Jehangir Nicholson Gallery, Mumbai, until Feb. 23**

VISUAL ODYSSEY
Clockwise from left, 'The Kingdom of Kush' by Delphine Diallo; 'Meet Me in the Garden' by Farheen Fatima; 'The Archivist' by Nony Singh; 'Cecilia'ed' by Indu Antony







EXHIBITION

CHENNAI IN FOCUS

The fourth edition of the **Chennai Photo Biennale** questions photography's purpose in an age of hyperdocumentation

"Why photograph?" is the question the Chennai Photo Biennale asks, as it returns with its fourth edition after a three-year physical hiatus since 2021, expanding its presence across more prominent venues in the city by occupying galleries and public spaces in Chennai.

The question takes inspiration from photographer Dayanita Singh's body of work, which inquires into the very act of photographing in an age of hyperdocumentation, as lines between fact and fiction blur more than ever. "Photography has become a spontaneous act and a universal language now. In this age of excess image production, the question that begs to be asked and answered not just by photographers and artists, but by anyone, is—why do we photograph?" says Shuchi Kapoor, co-founder and director, CPB Foundation, the charitable trust behind the biennale.

It's an age of paradoxes like no other. Today, while everyone owns a camera, the act of photographing runs the risk of propaganda, according to Kapoor. And yet, "it offers the liberty of sharing hyperlocal narratives and lesser-known cultural contexts," she says. The exhibition, thus, examines the present, past and future alike by assembling lens-based artists from across Tamil Nadu; showcasing the works of women who have documented their worlds through a lens that's uniquely theirs; spotlighting the works of children, and hosting retrospectives of artists like Sunil Gupta.

Also, for the very first time, the biennale is featuring 40 photographers from across 30 countries, with each participant handpicked by an esteemed international jury comprising *Vogue Italia* and *L'Uomo Vogue* senior photo editor Alessia Glaviano, celebrated Australian curator Brendan McCleary, award-winning Indian photographer Joseph Radhik, India Art Fair external relations and outreach director Umah Jacob, among others. This diverse jury is a testament to CPB's goal of playfully demystifying—and thereby making more accessible—photography for the common person, as the art exists in myriad contexts.

The biennale is also a step in the direction of encouraging a community of artists in the city to imagine it as a creative space, something the event's director Varun Gupta believes is a tangible cultural gap in Chennai. "In the early stages, we chose Chennai not only because we love it, but also because the city doesn't motivate younger people to enter the field of arts, and nothing can motivate people like a big exhibition such as a photo biennale," he says. The biggest incentive to do so, perhaps, is the fact that the biennale is open for free to everyone, and is on display till March 16. ■

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–Arshia